



FIGURE 8.7A–C A gazelle horn used in *al-Sadu* weaving.

4 *Al-Sadu* Symbols and Social Significance

Perhaps the main reason for the uniqueness of *al-Sadu* weaving is that it was never mass-produced for export in the same way other carpets were. Although it was traded among tribes, due to the length of time it takes to produce a tent, and due to its particular function in the harsh climate of the desert, it was not replicable in other geographies. *Al-Sadu* weaving could not be commercialized in the same way that other



FIGURE 8.8 Symbol of stars in contemporary *al-Sadu* weaving by Leila Yaser.

objects—such as *kilims*, clothes, bags, blankets, and tablecloths—were in other parts of the world. Therefore, although the weaving practice and the symbols used may have changed, they did not change as much as in other textiles, so examining the symbols embedded in these weavings may yield a wealth of information about the life of local populations. In the absence of written records, *al-Sadu* weavings become, thus, records of memories embodied in a thing.

The natural environment of the nomadic tribe can be seen in *al-Sadu* designs, which contain symbols that reflect astronomical elements and the desert environment.²⁴ Quite frequently, *al-Sadu* symbols indicate constellations and stars (fig. 8.8).²⁵ In the vast sky of the pre-electric desert, the stars, the moon, and the sun had a great significance, being the main sources of orientation. It is important to note that, currently, the weavers in Kuwait explain these symbols simply as “stars,”

24 For more details on the symbols that appear in *al-Sadu* weavings, see also Altaf Salem Al-Ali Al-Sabah, *Ibjad: Ornate Tent Dividers and Weavings of the Kuwait Desert* (Kuwait: Al Sadu Society, 2006); Khawla Mohamed Abdel and Aziez Al Manai, *Al Sadu* (Doha: National Museum of Qatar, 2013); and Ali S. Alnajadah, “The Pictographic Codes in Al-Sadu Weavings of Kuwait,” *International Design Journal* 8, no. 3 (2018): 63–74. In this latter study, Alnajadah tracks changes in the meanings of some *al-Sadu* symbols.

25 Khawlah M. Manna, *Al-Sadu in Qatar: Traditional Technical Values and Techniques* (Doha: Qatar Museums Authority, Qatar National Museum, 2013), 99–100.